2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante SamuelAlejo

Grade / Grado 10

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Noe Alejo

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

" Échale ganas. " Two simple words my father always said throughout my life, words that mean " give it your all, " but to me, mean everything. My father never attended high school; he earned his GED and learned English after coming to the United States legally. Even though I knew this throughout my life, it never held me back from trying my hardest, as he always told me to do.

He truly came from nothing, but still gave me everything. While growing up, my father worked as a long-distance truck driver, also known as an OTR. He traveled all across the country from the border of Canada to the state of Arizona, and even when he was out for weeks at a time, he would never forget about me. My dad would always call when he could and bring me toys from everywhere that he went. My father always made sure I had everything I needed, from sending me to a private school at a young age to making sure I had food to eat. He truly came from nothing, but still gave me everything.

A specific memory I can never forget is from my third-grade year in elementary school. On this day specifically, my father was supposed to be out for weeks. I remember I was sad since I knew my dad couldn ' t be there with me, but to my surprise, he walked into my classroom holding cupcakes for everyone to celebrate my birthday. Even now, this moment means everything to me. Later, he left his job because he realized he couldn ' t be away from his family for so long.

Between the summer of my seventh and eighth-grade years, my father told me the same words he always told me, " Échale ganas. " At the time, I thought he wanted me to work harder, stay disciplined, and respect others, but I now realize the true meaning behind those two simple words. The truth is, my dad wanted me to succeed, to take advantage of the opportunities he was never given, and to build a better future than his. I still remember how proud he was of me at my eighth-grade graduation when I received every award offered, and earned the spot as class salutatorian, an award he was never even offered.

Looking back to when I was young, I now understand the way he raised me and why. When I was younger, I thought he was just being strict when he wouldn ' t let me ride my bike further than within our block, when I had to be home before dark, and when I wasn ' t allowed to sleep over at a friend ' s house, but now I realize this was only how he was protecting me. Even if he was tired after work, he could have watched me play outside all day if he could.

Knowing what my father has gone through is what pushed me to have a strong work ethic, set high goals, and be disciplined. Everything I do is to make him proud. Each memory I remember of him comes with a meaning. Each story he has told me comes with a hidden message. Each word he tells me is for a reason. Those two unforgettable words are ones that will stick with me forever: " Échale

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

My father did not even know I was doing an essay about him. Once I showed him he told me to keep doing what I am doing, keep doing good in school, and keep making him proud. He was so happy to see me surpise him with an essay. When he read everything I wrote, he realized that all of the small things he has done for me, make a great impact on me.

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.